NKS CAPITAL

THE PROFESSIONAL EXECUTIVE ASSISTANT

The executive partnership

A practical guide to clear expectations, sound judgement and reliable support

LEARNING UNIT 01

READING EDITION 0.8 / OCTOBER 2026

About this reading edition

NKS Capital | Executive Assistant | Learning Unit 01

The Professional Executive Assistant and the Executive Partnership

This book supports learning about a professional executive-support partnership. It preserves the complete source-reading content supplied with the LU1 review course, including its tools, references and word help. The printed layout has been rebuilt for comfortable reading; no chapter has been summarised or omitted.

Meridian Services and the people and arrangements in its teaching case are fictional. Course examples do not grant workplace authority. Real organisational names in the references are source attributions, not fictional-case employer identities.

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Five case illustrations and the cover image reuse existing course assets. Their captions identify the scenes as fictional. Paid download and printed-book ordering will be handled by the learning platform, not by this review file.

Source and editorial integrity

Frozen source: source-reading.html, captured before replacement of the online reader. The source text and paragraph coverage ledger are retained with the authoring files. Typographic dash characters are normalised to ASCII hyphens for this print edition. Wording, explicit times and the distinction between requests and accepted commitments are unchanged.

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A note to the reader

A good executive-support relationship is not built on an assistant knowing everything, agreeing to everything or remaining available forever. It is built on a more demanding achievement: important work becomes clear, the right people can make the right decisions, and commitments can be relied upon. This learning unit explains how to create that relationship deliberately.

This first unit of The Executive Assistant's Complete Guide to Professional Support and Protective Coordination is for aspiring and experienced EAs and PAs. It develops purpose, trust, judgement, authority, expectations and sustainable cover. Later units develop the detailed administrative work and coordination with an Executive Protection Officer and an independent remote control room.

The working methods, dialogue and templates are original teaching material developed from the course research and learning outcomes. External references support the background points identified in the text; they do not endorse the course. [R1; R2]

The Meridian people, business, appointments, financial limits and service arrangements are fictional. Example times and limits are not operating standards. Use fictional or sanitised learning information (details removed or changed to avoid exposing real people or operations), never real family records, live movements or restricted alert details. Workplace practice requires the organisation's actual authority and reviewed procedures.

What you will be able to produce

The main outcome is to establish an executive-support working agreement that aligns business priorities, delegated authority, information access and sustainable cover arrangements. The five supporting outcomes are reproduced below so that the unit's purpose is visible. [R2, EA-01]

Outcome	Performance to demonstrate
EA-01.1	Translate an executive brief into agreed support priorities, deliverables and review points.
EA-01.2	Prepare a working agreement covering diary access, decision and spending limits, communication preferences, confidentiality, personal tasks and availability.
EA-01.3	Distinguish EA responsibilities from those of a personal assistant, office manager, chief of staff and specialist adviser, and refer work outside the agreed mandate.
EA-01.4	Present options and consequences when demands compete, including effects on preparation, time, cost, wellbeing and required protective decisions.
EA-01.5	Agree a safe route for raising concerns, resolving expectations and arranging an authorised deputy without making the role dependent on permanent availability.

Your principal work products will be a working agreement and a reasoned priority-and-delegation exercise. Read the worked examples before using the blank tools. The reflection guidance near the end explains defensible responses; it is not a substitute for thinking through the question yourself.

1.1 Why this book exists

Illustrative fictional case: Daniel checks a request before treating it as a confirmed commitment.

1.1.1 The morning that exposes the real job

At 07:40 on a Monday, Daniel opens a message from Lindiwe, the executive he supports at the fictional company Meridian Services. "Please move the 11:30 client discussion to lunch at the client's venue. Fit in the supplier before that. I will sort out transport with Thandi."

The existing programme contains a 09:30 preparation period, a 10:00 decision meeting, an 11:30 virtual client discussion, a private commitment at 12:30 and an afternoon site visit. A supplier has independently asked Daniel for 09:45, saying that the executive expects to see them. The afternoon visit has an accepted protective and monitoring arrangement. No one has yet confirmed whether the proposed lunch venue falls within it.

Nothing in the message is necessarily suspicious. Executives change plans. Clients make requests. Suppliers misunderstand availability. The difficulty is that several different decisions are being compressed into one apparently simple instruction. If Daniel merely changes the diary, he may remove preparation the executive needs, create an impossible overlap, imply that a supplier appointment was approved and leave different people working from different versions of the day.

Daniel's first useful contribution is therefore not speed at the keyboard. It is making the situation intelligible. What is the purpose of the supplier discussion? Must Lindiwe attend? Is lunch essential, or is

the client asking for a longer conversation? Which arrangements has Thandi, the Executive Protection Officer, actually accepted? Does Lindiwe intend to retain the private commitment? Who may decide these points while she is unavailable?

This is the kind of work the book develops. It includes excellent administration, but it also requires judgement about information, dependencies (inputs or decisions another task needs), authority and communication. The assistant should neither act as an unquestioning messenger nor seize decisions that belong to someone else.

KEY POINT | The professional contribution

The EA makes important work easier to decide, prepare, perform and follow through. A tidy calendar is one product of that contribution, not its complete definition.

1.1.2 From completing tasks to making commitments reliable

Consider the instruction "Arrange the meeting." At the most basic level, a meeting invitation can be created quickly. Yet the intended result may require an approved agenda, a decision paper, a participant with authority to commit resources, suitable access arrangements and enough time for the executive to prepare. Sending the invitation does not establish that those conditions exist.

A useful distinction is between an activity, an output and an outcome. Sending invitations is an activity. A confirmed meeting pack is an output. A decision taken on sufficiently reliable information is an intended business outcome. The EA may own the administrative output without owning the executive's decision. Good support makes that distinction clear rather than claiming credit for everything that follows.

In this book, reliability means that other people can tell what has been agreed, what has been checked, what remains uncertain and who must act next. A reliable assistant does not promise that nothing will change. The promise is that material change will not be hidden behind an outdated record or an unsupported statement that everything is fine.

This changes the meaning of initiative. Initiative is not performing unrequested specialist work or bypassing an approval because it seems convenient. It can be recognising an impending conflict, preparing two feasible alternatives and asking for a decision before the conflict becomes urgent. It can also mean recording that a booking is still provisional rather than making it look complete.

1.1.3 Why protective coordination belongs in ordinary support

The programme joins executive support to a protective-support arrangement involving the EA, the EPO and an independent remote control room. In the research model, the EA maintains the administrative plan and coordinates information; the EPO makes protective assessments within mandate; and the control room accepts and manages defined monitoring and assistance tasks. These are connected responsibilities, not interchangeable jobs. [R1, sections 6-7]

Word help: A mandate is the agreed scope and authority of a role. It must be read with the organisation’s requirements; a job title or access to the executive is not enough.

The companion tiger-kidnapping awareness guide identifies executive-support personnel as people who may hold sensitive knowledge of appointments, routines, contacts and access arrangements. Its

significance here is the need for careful handling and an accessible reporting route, not a reason to make the EA an investigator. [A1, pp. 6 and 11]

In practical terms, an ordinary change can have protective consequences. An appointment moved from a virtual meeting to a different physical location can affect transport, arrival arrangements, specialist review and the period for which monitoring is required. The EA's responsibility is to recognise those interfaces and bring the required people into the decision. It is not to declare the location safe.

Equally, protection cannot replace ordinary competence. An elaborate support structure is of little help when the executive has the wrong document, the host expects a different arrival time or the replacement assistant cannot find the current arrangements. The professional partnership must make business support and protective coordination reinforce one another.

1.1.4 What this unit does not ask of you

This unit does not ask you to become a substitute executive, chief of staff, clinician, protection officer or incident commander. It does not define one universal employment arrangement, give permission to collect private information or promise that a support service will always respond. Those matters require actual authority and relevant professional input.

The dedicated boundaries unit, LU2, will develop limits of authority in depth. You should nevertheless apply a simple principle from the beginning: when a task exceeds your mandate, identify the appropriate owner and support a proper referral. Do not conceal the gap, and do not abandon a legitimate need merely because you cannot personally fulfil every part of it.

Reflection 1. In the opening case, what could Daniel complete immediately, and what would remain a request or assumption? Name the decision that must be obtained before an apparent diary change can be described as a coordinated arrangement.

1.2 The EA's role and professional contribution

1.2.1 A broad role, not an unlimited one

O*NET's occupational description includes research, reports, correspondence, information requests, scheduling and routine administrative work. Its task list also includes executive travel and meeting preparation. This is a useful breadth check: executive administration involves more than booking appointments. It is a United States occupational reference, not a mandatory job description for every learner. [S1]

Your actual role begins with the employer's approved responsibilities and the executive's support needs. In one workplace, an EA may coordinate board papers and substantial projects. In another, the main work may be diary management, communication and travel. Some responsibilities may be shared. None of those arrangements should be inferred solely from the title on a business card.

The World Administrators Alliance makes a related point: administrative job titles vary between employers and countries, and the terms Personal Assistant and Executive Assistant can overlap. The practical lesson is to establish the work and authority rather than assume a fixed hierarchy between titles. [S2, p. 4]

The comparison below is a teaching aid, not a classification system. Use it to ask which responsibilities belong in your specific agreement.

Role	Useful distinction for agreeing the work
Executive Assistant	Coordinates defined executive-support work and makes the administrative judgements actually delegated to the role.
Personal Assistant	May provide overlapping professional or personal support; the title alone does not establish seniority or domestic responsibilities.
Office manager	May own workplace resources, office services and wider administrative arrangements. An EA liaises with that owner unless the duties are expressly combined.
Chief of staff	May have a wider organisational or strategic mandate. The EA should not assume that access to the executive confers that mandate.
Specialist adviser	Provides decisions or advice within an appointed professional discipline. The EA can prepare information and coordinate access without replacing the adviser.

1.2.2 Three forms of contribution

For the purposes of this book, think of the EA's contribution in three connected forms. First is production: preparing accurate correspondence, records, arrangements and work products. Second is judgement: identifying relevance, inconsistency, missing information and choices requiring a decision. Third is coordination: ensuring that the people who must act share the relevant understanding and accept their responsibilities.

These are not ranks in which coordination is superior to production. A perceptive assistant who produces unreliable documents creates problems. An accurate administrator who never questions an impossible instruction also creates problems. The aim is a balanced practice in which competent execution is accompanied by proportionate judgement and dependable follow-through.

PRODUCE Accurate documents, arrangements and records. | JUDGE Identify relevance, conflicts and missing information. | COORDINATE Obtain decisions, acceptance and dependable follow-through.

Figure 1.1 - Three connected forms of professional contribution. The three forms reinforce one another; they are not ranks or separate jobs.

For example, preparing Lindiwe's decision pack is production. Noticing that the financial appendix is an unapproved draft is judgement. Asking the finance owner for the approved version, agreeing a deadline and informing Lindiwe of the remaining gap is coordination. Daniel does not need to become the financial decision-maker to perform any of those tasks well.

This perspective also helps explain value to a manager. Instead of saying only "I processed eighteen requests," Daniel can explain that the approved pack reached the decision-makers in time, one unverified assumption was exposed, and two conflicting commitments were resolved by an authorised decision. He should retain evidence, not manufacture a story of crises averted.

1.2.3 Access is a responsibility, not personal power

An assistant may be a frequent point of contact for an executive. That position should make legitimate work easier to navigate, not make the assistant a private gatekeeper of favour. Apply agreed priorities and appointment rules consistently. Explain the route to a decision rather than suggesting that people must cultivate a personal relationship with you to obtain access.

There is an important difference between speaking for the executive and conveying an instruction from the executive. You may be authorised to confirm an agreed appointment or send approved wording. That does not necessarily authorise you to negotiate a commitment, change a financial term or express an executive opinion. State the capacity in which you are communicating when the distinction matters.

An appropriate message might read: "Lindiwe has approved a twenty-minute discussion on the stated agenda. I am coordinating the arrangements. Any commercial decision remains with the appointed business owner." The wording is clear without being defensive. It prevents the recipient from assuming that administrative coordination carries commercial authority.

Do not use privileged access to bypass another department's legitimate process. A message sent from the executive office should make the source and approval clear; it should not become an informal instruction to ignore verification or conceal an exception.

1.2.4 Professional standards in everyday behaviour

The standard proposed here combines accuracy, discretion, fairness, reliability and constructive candour. Here, constructive candour means speaking honestly about a problem or uncertainty in a respectful, useful way. Accuracy includes checking a name, date or attachment before sending it. Discretion includes choosing the right recipients rather than sharing everything with a familiar group. Fairness includes applying the same legitimate process to a confident visitor and a less influential colleague.

Reliability includes doing what you have agreed and communicating early when that becomes impossible. Candour includes saying "I have not confirmed that yet" without presenting uncertainty as incompetence. Those behaviours are observable. They should form part of feedback and development rather than remaining attractive words in a job description.

They also place obligations on the executive and organisation. The assistant needs a workable mandate, access to relevant information and a credible route for resolving conflicting demands. A person should not be evaluated against an expectation that was never explained or against a service no one authorised them to obtain. [R1, sections 1 and 5.1]

BOUNDARY | A combined job still needs defined permissions

A small organisation may combine EA, office administration and personal support. Combining duties does not automatically combine every approval, data-access right or specialist competence associated with those duties. State what is combined and what remains separately controlled.

Reflection 2. A manager says, "You have direct access to the chief executive, so please approve this supplier exception." How would you distinguish useful assistance from a decision you have not been delegated?

1.3 Understanding the executive's business priorities

Illustrative fictional case: a controlled decision pack is a support deliverable, not the executive decision itself.

1.3.1 Learn the purpose before designing the diary

The first professional question is not "How full is the calendar?" It is "What does the executive need to achieve, and what support makes that possible?" A full calendar can still be badly aligned with the work. An apparently quiet period can be essential preparation for a decision that affects many other commitments.

Begin with an executive brief. It need not be an elaborate strategy document. It should explain the executive's principal responsibilities, the outcomes currently requiring attention, the decisions that only that person or another named authority can take, and the important deadlines or relationships. Ask which commitments are genuinely fixed and which reflect a preference that may be adjusted.

The EA Campus's public calendar-management outline emphasises aligning executive time with priorities and preparing ahead of conflicts. In this unit, that broad idea becomes a practical working method: agree

the business purpose before applying diary rules. The detailed method and tools here are original course material, not reproductions of the provider's worksheets. [S3]

1.3.2 Turn broad intentions into support requirements

An executive may describe a priority as "Improve the client relationship." That tells you the desired direction, but not yet the support requirement. A useful follow-up is: "What should be different after the next discussion?" The answer might be that a disputed service issue is assigned to an owner, a recovery plan is agreed and the client knows when to expect an update.

Now the administrative requirements become clearer. The meeting needs the service owner, a current factual briefing and a record of the actions agreed. The executive may need preparation before the discussion. A ceremonial lunch might support the relationship, but it should not displace the people or information needed to address the actual issue.

Use these six questions to clarify the brief.

What result is needed?

Why is it needed now?

What decision or contribution is needed from the executive?

What must be ready?

Who is responsible for each input?

What will show that the work is complete, or ready for review?

They help you translate a broad brief into supportable work without taking over the substantive business decision.

For Meridian's Monday decision meeting, the result is a decision on a proposed service investment. Daniel's contribution is not to decide whether the investment is sound. It is to establish which approved papers are required, confirm their owners and delivery times, protect preparation time and make any missing input visible to Lindiwe.

1.3.3 A worked priority translation

The following example uses fictional requirements. It shows how a vague request becomes a support commitment with evidence.

Executive intention	Agreed EA deliverable	Decision or input owner	Review point and evidence
Make the investment decision on Monday.	Prepare a controlled pack with the approved agenda and referenced papers.	Lindiwe owns the decision; finance and operations own their submissions.	Pack-readiness review before preparation; missing items listed explicitly.

Executive intention	Agreed EA deliverable	Decision or input owner	Review point and evidence
Restore client confidence.	Coordinate the appropriate discussion and an accurate action record.	Client-account lead owns the substantive response; Lindiwe confirms her contribution.	Review the purpose before confirming format; record agreed owners and dates afterwards.
Complete the site visit without disrupting essential work.	Reconcile the visit with the programme and required support decisions.	Operations owns the visit purpose; Thandi owns protective input; the room accepts monitoring scope.	Check dependencies at the agreed briefing and on a material change.

The rightmost column matters. "Prepare the pack" is ambiguous until the people involved agree when it will be reviewed and how its status will be demonstrated. A missing paper must not disappear merely because the cover sheet is complete. The assistant should show the gap and the implications for the executive's preparation.

1.3.4 Urgency, importance and constraints

Urgency concerns timing: when is action required? Importance concerns consequences: what happens if the work is not done, or is done badly? A third consideration is dependency: does another activity rely on this one? A fourth is authority: who may decide that one commitment takes precedence over another?

These questions are better than a rule that every request from the most senior person wins. Seniority may determine who decides, but it does not make two simultaneous appointments feasible. Nor does a red flag in a message tell you whether a deadline is external, self-imposed or simply convenient to the sender.

Ask for the consequence of delay without making the person feel interrogated. "To place this correctly, what decision depends on it and what is the latest useful time?" is often more useful than "Is it really urgent?" Where immediate danger is credible, use the appropriate emergency route rather than turn the situation into a prioritisation exercise.

Constraints should be recorded at the level needed for the task. A private appointment may be represented by a protected time block and relevant availability, without disclosing its personal purpose. Accessibility, preparation and reasonable travel time are real planning requirements; they should not be treated as optional simply because they do not look like meetings.

1.3.5 Working with more than one executive

When supporting several executives, create one view of your capacity alongside the separate views of their priorities. Otherwise each executive may assume that your apparently unoccupied hour belongs entirely to them. Agree a method for resolving conflicts and name the manager who can decide when the competing demands cannot be reconciled within your authority.

Avoid revealing one executive's confidential business to justify a delay to another. You can explain that an agreed deadline or protected task occupies the available capacity without naming sensitive content. Where a decision needs more detail, send that detail only through the appropriate confidential route.

Do not promise simultaneous completion and then compensate with unrecorded hours. Show the work, the realistic capacity and the options. The choices may be to reschedule, reduce scope, assign another person or change a deadline through an authorised decision. A well-described capacity conflict is useful management information.

Reflection 3. Convert "Make sure I am ready for the board discussion" into a support requirement. Include a deliverable, an input owner, a review point and a statement of what you will do if a required paper remains unapproved.

1.4 Building the working relationship

1.4.1 Trust should make questions easier

Trust is not the absence of checking. In a professional partnership, trust makes it possible to ask a necessary question without either person interpreting it as disloyalty. An executive should be able to rely on the assistant's work; the assistant should be able to rely on the executive's willingness to clarify intent and support legitimate boundaries.

An effective relationship starts with a conversation about expectations rather than a guess about personality. Ask how the executive wants to receive decisions, how much detail is useful, which matters may be batched, and which circumstances justify an interruption. Explain what information you need to fulfil the role and what can go wrong when changes reach you late.

Do not turn working preferences into a private personality dossier. Record practical preferences that affect the service: document format, briefing style, accessibility arrangements, contact channels and decision points. Avoid subjective labels about mood or personal characteristics. A future deputy needs useful instructions, not gossip disguised as a handover.

1.4.2 Agree a communication rhythm

A communication rhythm provides predictable opportunities to settle priorities and exceptions. It may include a short start-of-day alignment, a brief review of unresolved decisions and a longer periodic discussion about the support arrangement. The exact frequency should fit the role and operating environment. More meetings are not inherently better.

Distinguish three different things: receipt, decision and completion. A quick "received" message may reassure a sender that the request has reached you, but it is not approval or proof that the work is finished. A useful acknowledgement could say: "I have the request. It conflicts with the existing preparation period. I am checking options and will return the decision brief at the time agreed."

Choose channels by purpose and sensitivity. A routine task may belong in the approved task system. A decision that changes the executive's commitments may require direct confirmation. A sensitive matter may need a restricted route. A voice conversation can be entirely appropriate, but a material decision should subsequently be captured in the controlled record so that others do not rely on memory alone.

The working agreement must also explain what happens when a normal channel fails. Do not create a complicated collection of parallel groups that no one knows how to monitor. Establish an approved

alternative and identify which record remains authoritative after the conversation moves between channels.

1.4.3 Ask questions that help the executive decide

A question is most useful when it exposes a choice. Compare "What must I do about lunch?" with "Keeping lunch at the new venue will remove the protected 12:30 commitment and requires a revised protective decision. Keeping the client discussion virtual preserves the present programme. Which business option should I take forward?"

The second question does more work. It presents the known consequence, identifies a remaining specialist dependency and avoids pretending that a calendar edit can settle everything. It also allows the executive to correct the assumption: perhaps the private commitment can move, or perhaps lunch was only a preference.

Questions should be concise but not stripped of essential uncertainty. Do not turn a conditional option into a promise merely to make the message shorter. "Possible, subject to approval and availability" is materially different from "Arranged." The assistant should use words that accurately represent the state of the work.

1.4.4 Constructive challenge and respectful refusal

Constructive challenge begins with the shared objective. "I want to preserve the client discussion and ensure you arrive prepared" is a better opening than "That will not work." Then state the relevant facts, the boundary or conflict, the options and the decision needed. This method addresses the work rather than attacking the person making the request.

There will be times when an alternative is not immediately available. A request may be outside your authority or inconsistent with an established control. In that situation, explain what you can do: verify the requirement, locate the correct decision-maker, prepare the information or route the concern. Avoid using "not my job" as the end of the conversation when a legitimate need remains.

At the same time, helpfulness does not require compliance with abusive, coercive or unsafe behaviour. Use the organisation's designated reporting and support routes for concerns of that nature. A working agreement should not make the executive being complained about the only available recipient. This is a proposed course safeguard; actual reporting arrangements must be established by the organisation. [R1, sections 1 and 5.1]

WORKED DIALOGUE | A boundary without a confrontation

Executive: "Just give the supplier whatever information will get this done."

EA: "I can give them the approved requirements and the contact for access coordination. I do not have authority to release the full diary or family information. I will establish exactly what they need and refer any additional request to the authorised owner."

The EA keeps the legitimate task moving while separating it from an unjustified disclosure.

1.4.5 Recovering from an error

Professionalism does not mean never making a mistake. It means responding in a way that protects the work and the people affected. When you discover an error, establish the known facts, consider immediate consequences, inform the appropriate person, correct the controlled record and confirm that affected recipients have the correction.

Do not quietly replace an attachment and assume that everyone will notice. Do not minimise a possible information exposure because the recipient is friendly. Do not exaggerate an administrative error into a catastrophe either. Describe what occurred, what is affected, what is being corrected and what remains to be checked.

After the immediate correction, review the cause. Was the mistake an individual checking failure, an unclear source, an inaccessible approval, an unrealistic workload or a process that allowed several incompatible versions? The answer should guide improvement. A demand to "be more careful" is incomplete when the system itself makes the correct version difficult to find.

Reflection 4. Write a short message correcting an appointment time that you previously sent incorrectly. Make the correction clear, identify any consequential action and obtain the acknowledgement needed from the people who must act.

1.5 Delegation, authority and access

1.5.1 Responsibility needs usable authority

Delegation should answer more than "Who is doing this?" It should establish the result required, the choices the person may make, the limits that apply and how completion will be demonstrated. A vague instruction can transfer pressure without transferring the permission needed to do the work.

Suppose Daniel is told to manage all changes to Lindiwe's day but is unable to see several appointments and has no authority to move any commitment. He cannot make the whole programme reliable merely by working harder. He needs an agreed visibility arrangement, a decision route and a way to represent protected commitments without exposing unnecessary detail.

The same principle applies to services. If the organisation wants Daniel to coordinate monitoring, he needs to know which activities the provider covers, how assignments are accepted and who resolves an uncovered period. He cannot create a service obligation by sending a schedule to a generic address. [R1, sections 1 and 6]

UK HSE guidance on role clarity emphasises clear responsibilities, compatible requirements and routes for raising uncertainty or conflict. It supports the general importance of resolving these issues, but it is not presented here as South African employment law. The delegation method below is the course's own teaching approach. [S4]

1.5.2 Keep four questions separate

A person may be capable of a task without being authorised to perform it. A person may have access to a system without being permitted to use every function. A person may be assigned responsibility without having adequate time or resources. These are different conditions and should be checked separately.

For any material task, check each condition separately.

Can I do this work to the required standard?

Am I authorised to do it?

Do I have the information and access I need?

Are enough time and resources available?

If one condition is absent, name the gap and identify who can resolve it. Do not assume that a password, senior instruction or previous informal practice resolves all four questions.

COMPETENCE Can I do the work to the required standard? | AUTHORITY Am I permitted to make this decision or act? | INFORMATION Do I have the necessary facts and access? | CAPACITY Are the time and resources available?

Figure 1.2 - Four conditions for accepting a responsibility. A missing condition calls for clarification, support or referral, not an invented confirmation.

For example, Daniel may know how to amend supplier records in a system but lack authority to approve a change to banking details. Conversely, he may be authorised to reconcile an itinerary but lack access to a late change entered by another office. The first requires an approval or verification route; the second requires a proper information-access arrangement. Both should be visible before completion is claimed.

1.5.3 A usable delegation record

The following six fields form an original practical model for this course. They can be recorded in a simple task system or working agreement; the format is less important than the information.

Field	Question it must answer
Result	What must be produced, coordinated or decided?
Scope	What may the EA do independently, and what remains with another person?
Conditions	Which policy, budget, information, supplier or protective requirements apply?
Decision route	Who approves an exception, and who acts when that person is unavailable?
Evidence	What record or acknowledgement demonstrates completion?
Review or expiry	When does the delegation end or require reconsideration?

Apply the model to a routine meeting. Daniel may be authorised to move an internal administrative catch-up within an agreed window, provided it does not displace a protected commitment, create a cost or change a location requiring specialist input. He records the current time and obtains the relevant participant confirmations. Moving a board decision or an external visit falls outside that routine delegation.

The important feature is the boundary condition. "Manage the diary" is too broad to explain which decisions can be made independently. The practical record tells Daniel when normal discretion ends and an approval or specialist decision begins.

1.5.4 Four responses to a request

Within this teaching model, assess the exact action and choose the appropriate response.

Act when you are competent, authorised and all applicable conditions are met.

Seek approval when a legitimate task exceeds your existing decision or spending limit.

Refer the task when the decision or work belongs to a specialist or another appointed owner.

Decline the requested action and escalate it when it is outside your role or conflicts with a control you cannot override.

These are not four levels of importance. A minor request can involve an unauthorised disclosure. A significant administrative task can still be fully delegated. The appropriate response depends on the action and its conditions, not on the volume of the requester's voice.

Nor does referral mean forgetting the task. Daniel can record that the EPO is assessing a changed venue, identify the required decision time and ensure that the business plan does not present the venue as approved in the meantime. He coordinates the referral without making the protective judgement himself.

1.5.5 Access should match the task

Use approved individual accounts and delegated access rather than sharing an executive's password. Agree which calendar details, documents and contact records the EA needs to perform the role. A protected appointment can expose the period of unavailability without exposing a medical or family explanation. A deputy should receive the access required for the cover period, not an unrestricted copy of the executive's history.

Do not interpret a refusal to disclose unnecessary detail as an obstacle to professional support. Ask which minimum facts will make the arrangement workable. Sometimes the solution is a confidential decision route rather than wider visibility. Sometimes the executive must accept that a particular service cannot be coordinated unless essential information is supplied through an appropriate channel.

Where an instruction conflicts with policy, delegated authority or another binding requirement, stop treating it as routine. Seek a resolution from the appropriate organisational owner. This unit does not adjudicate legal conflicts or grant exceptions; LU2 will develop the boundary decisions further.

KEY POINT | Authority is specific

Permission to arrange is not automatically permission to approve, pay, disclose, speak publicly or direct a specialist. Record the decision right that is actually delegated.

Reflection 5. Draft a delegation record for routine meeting changes. Include one condition that permits independent action and two changes that must be referred for approval or specialist input.

1.6 Managing competing demands

Illustrative fictional case: compare feasible options and their conditions before promising a change.

1.6.1 Make the trade-off visible

A competing-demand problem is not always a failure of time management. The organisation may have asked for more work than the available person or time can support. The EA's professional task is to expose the choice early enough for a decision, not hide the conflict until one commitment fails.

Start with the known commitments and the result of the new request. Identify what is fixed, what can move, which preparation is required and which approvals or services would be affected. Separate facts from assumptions. "The supplier says Lindiwe agreed" is a report that needs verification; it is not itself proof of executive approval.

Then construct feasible alternatives. A useful option states what changes, what is preserved, what it costs in time or resources, and which conditions must still be satisfied. An option that relies on an unavailable person or an unapproved service should be labelled conditional, not presented as ready to implement.

1.6.2 The supplier request, worked through

Return to the Meridian case. Daniel has the following verified programme: preparation from 09:30 to 10:00; an executive decision meeting from 10:00 to 10:45; and a virtual client discussion at 11:30. The supplier requests thirty minutes at 09:45. Daniel has not verified the claim that Lindiwe approved this time.

There are two immediate conflicts. The supplier discussion would consume the last fifteen minutes of preparation and the first fifteen minutes of the decision meeting. Shortening preparation without telling Lindiwe would make the diary look more flexible than the work really is. Moving the decision meeting is outside Daniel's routine delegation.

Read the diary before accepting the request

Record	09:30-09:45	09:45-10:00	10:00-10:15	10:15-10:45
Verified programme	Preparation	Preparation	Decision meeting	Decision meeting
Supplier request	No request	Requested overlap	Requested overlap	No request
What this means	Protect preparation	15 minutes lost if accepted	15 minutes of meeting affected	Meeting continues

Reading aid 1A. The supplier’s 09:45-10:15 request overlaps 15 minutes of preparation and 15 minutes of the decision meeting. It is not an accepted appointment. Source: section 1.6.2; fictional Meridian case.

Daniel asks the supplier to state the purpose and the decision required. The supplier explains that they need agreement on a delivery sequence, not a new commercial commitment. Daniel can now ask whether the operations owner should handle the discussion and provide an exception brief to Lindiwe. This is an option, not a decision Daniel makes simply because it seems efficient.

Option	What it preserves	Consequence or condition
Refer the delivery-sequence discussion to the operations owner.	Executive preparation and the decision meeting.	Lindiwe must approve the delegation where required; the operations owner must accept the task and report exceptions.
Offer a later suitable executive slot.	Existing morning commitments.	The supplier must confirm the latest useful decision time and accept the alternative.
Change the existing morning commitments.	Direct executive attendance at the supplier meeting.	Requires Lindiwe's decision, consultation with affected participants and explicit acceptance of reduced preparation or a moved deadline.

The first option may be best, but Daniel should not hide its conditions. A clear recommendation could be: "I recommend that operations handle the delivery-sequence discussion and send you any unresolved decision. That protects the preparation and the 10:00 meeting. Please confirm the delegation; I will then obtain the operations owner's acceptance and update the supplier."

This is a more useful contribution than silently declining the supplier or promising that Lindiwe can do everything. It protects executive choice by making consequences visible.

1.6.3 The lunch request is a different kind of change

Moving the 11:30 virtual client discussion to lunch at a different venue is not only a timing question. It may affect the private 12:30 block, transport and the scope of the EPO and control-room arrangements. The business preference can be discussed before the logistics are complete, but the changed arrangement must remain conditional until the required decisions and confirmations exist.

Daniel can offer to retain the virtual discussion, arrange an alternative date for a physical meeting, or take the proposed lunch forward for the necessary checks. He should not tell the client that the physical meeting is confirmed while still waiting to hear what Thandi has accepted.

The decision brief should distinguish business approval from protective and service acceptance. "Lindiwe would prefer the lunch option" does not mean the EPO has assessed it. "Thandi is aware of the request" does not mean the control room has accepted revised monitoring. LU8 and LU9 develop that coordination in detail; the LU1 lesson is to recognise that one person's approval does not answer every question.

1.6.4 A short decision brief

Use this order when a decision needs to be made quickly.

State the result requested.

Explain the existing constraint.

Describe the workable options.

Give your recommendation and reason.

State who needs to decide and what they must decide.

Identify what is still conditional.

This is not a mandatory form for every small task. It is a way to prevent a busy decision-maker from having to reconstruct the problem from scattered messages.

For the supplier request, Daniel's brief might be only a paragraph. For a changed overseas trip, the equivalent brief may require a structured comparison and specialist input. Scale the record to the significance of the decision. Do not create paperwork that obscures the very choice it was intended to clarify.

After a decision, record what was authorised and by whom, update the current arrangement, communicate the consequences and obtain the necessary acceptance. A recommendation is not a decision. A decision is not completed implementation. Each stage has a different purpose.

01 REQUEST Define the result and expose the constraints. | 02 DECISION Obtain the appropriate authority and conditions. | 03 ACTION Implement and obtain required acknowledgements. | 04 CLOSURE Confirm completion or an accepted transfer.

Figure 1.3 - From a request to a reliable result. These are distinct states. Progress to the next one only when its required evidence exists.

1.6.5 When no decision arrives

Silence must not be converted into permission unless an explicit approved arrangement makes that response meaningful for the specific task. A message marked as read is not necessarily an approval. Record that the decision remains outstanding, use the agreed escalation route and explain the consequences of the decision not arriving in time.

Where the task is non-urgent, preserve the existing approved arrangement while making the unresolved request visible, unless the applicable procedure directs otherwise. Where credible immediate danger exists, use the emergency route rather than waiting for a routine calendar approval. The distinction should be clear in the working agreement and reinforced in later units.

Reflection 6. Prepare a short decision brief for the lunch request. Show the business choice separately from protective input and control-room acceptance. Do not invent confirmation that the case has not supplied.

1.7 Creating the executive-EA working agreement

Illustrative fictional case: record what the partnership includes, excludes and requires another person to approve.

1.7.1 An agreement that people can actually use

The working agreement converts expectations into an operating understanding between the executive, the EA and the organisational owners whose permissions or services are involved. It is not a substitute for an employment contract, policy, service contract or specialist procedure. It records how the support partnership will operate within those requirements.

An agreement can fail in two opposite ways. It can be so vague that everyone reads their own expectations into it: "provide excellent support" or "be flexible." It can also be so elaborate that neither party consults it. The objective is a usable document with clear commitments, decision rights, boundaries and review arrangements.

Write it through conversation. Drafting it in isolation and asking the executive to sign at the end may conceal disagreements until the first difficult day. Discuss examples: a visitor not on the list, a late change, an unexpected payment request, an unavailable executive, a family call and an evening journey continuing after the EA's duty period.

Where the agreement depends on another owner, obtain that owner's confirmation. The executive and EA cannot promise the control room's coverage on its behalf. A working agreement stating "monitoring is continuous" is not evidence of a service mandate.

1.7.2 The essential areas to settle

A useful agreement establishes purpose and priorities, the work included and excluded, information access, decision and spending authority, communication, confidentiality, personal tasks, availability, escalation, deputy arrangements and review. Each area should answer a practical question that might otherwise be settled by assumption. [R2, EA-01.2 and EA-01.5]

Purpose tells the assistant what the service is intended to enable. Scope prevents responsibility expanding through habit. Authority makes independent work possible without repeated unnecessary approvals. Access ensures that the assistant can see what the authorised task requires. Communication explains how decisions and exceptions travel. Cover explains how responsibility continues when a person is absent.

The agreement should also include mutual commitments. The executive provides relevant changes and decisions, supports legitimate verification and does not require the assistant to claim unconfirmed work is complete. The EA maintains accurate records, uses discretion, escalates gaps and reports progress honestly. A one-sided document cannot solve a two-sided coordination problem.

1.7.3 A fully worked example: Meridian partnership agreement

Teaching example. The agreement below is fictional and belongs only to the Meridian case. Its hours, spending limits and service periods are illustrative. They are not recommendations for actual employment terms or automatic permission for a learner to act.

Agreement identity and purpose. Record MP-01, version 1.0, applies to executive support for Lindiwe by Daniel. Its purpose is to support timely business decisions, accurate communication and coordinated commitments. It becomes effective in the fictional case only after the required parties confirm their responsibilities. It is reviewed after the first working month and whenever scope, personnel, systems or material service arrangements change.

1. Priorities and deliverables. Lindiwe confirms the current priority list and identifies decisions that require her attention. Daniel translates the list into a programme, preparation requirements, an action register and review points. For the Monday example, the decision pack and 09:30 preparation period are protected. Daniel identifies missing inputs; he does not approve the substantive financial or operational papers himself.

2. Scope of work. Daniel coordinates the diary, routine correspondence, meeting preparation, travel administration, relevant supplier follow-up and the administrative interfaces with the EPO and control room. Office facilities remain with the office-services owner. Contract interpretation remains with the designated legal or procurement owner. Public statements remain with the authorised communications function. Substantive business decisions stay with their appointed owners.

3. Diary access and protected information. Daniel receives approved delegated access sufficient to coordinate availability and business arrangements. Private commitments may appear as unavailable periods without a personal explanation. Where a private commitment affects agreed protective coverage, the necessary operational information goes through the approved restricted route. The existence of a protected block is not permission to investigate its purpose or disclose its detail.

4. Routine decision authority. Daniel may arrange and move routine internal administrative meetings within agreed available periods when no protected commitment, external undertaking, cost or specialist dependency is affected. Changes to executive decision meetings, external visits or protected periods

require the identified decision-maker's approval. A request received directly by Lindiwe is entered into the controlled process before others are told that consequential arrangements are complete.

5. Spending and supplier authority. In this fictional example only, Daniel may place orders for pre-approved meeting consumables up to R2,000 per event within an already approved budget and supplier process. He may not split purchases to avoid the limit. He may prepare a quotation comparison for larger expenditure but may not approve it or release payment. A change to supplier payment details goes to finance through the approved independent verification route. The executive's preference for a supplier does not remove these conditions.

6. Communication and decisions. A short alignment conversation takes place at a time agreed for the working day. Routine tasks are recorded in the approved task system. Material instructions given verbally are captured in the appropriate record. Daniel distinguishes receipt, approval and completion in status messages. A sensitive matter uses a restricted channel. Silence or a message read receipt is not treated as approval of a new commitment.

7. Changes and protective interfaces. Daniel identifies which changes affect the programme, transport, venue or support arrangements. Lindiwe decides the business preference within her authority. Thandi, the EPO, owns the required protective input. The remote control room accepts the relevant monitoring assignment under its actual mandate. Daniel maintains the administrative status and escalates unaccepted or uncovered activity. None of these parties is recorded as having approved another party's decision.

8. Confidentiality and family or personal tasks. Daniel uses only the information needed for the authorised task and limits distribution to appropriate recipients. In the fictional scope, he may coordinate agreed personal appointments or family administrative contact where the necessary permission and time have been established. He is not the household investigator, family dispute mediator or automatic incident spokesperson. New personal tasks are considered against scope, privacy, resources and competing business work before being accepted.

9. Availability and cover. Daniel's fictional normal support period is 08:00 to 17:00. This is a case fact, not an employment recommendation. Any planned work outside that period requires an agreed arrangement. Aisha is the appointed deputy for accepted cover periods, using her own authorised access. The control room's monitoring coverage is separately defined and does not depend on Daniel personally watching a phone after work. Neither the existence of Aisha nor the word "deputy" means that she has accepted every future assignment.

Word help: A deputy is an appointed person who covers defined work. The person still needs the required access, competence and explicit acceptance of that assignment.

10. Concerns and unresolved decisions. Routine priority conflicts go to Lindiwe or the designated substitute decision-maker. Concerns involving personal safety, improper conduct or the executive herself have an alternative organisational reporting route identified in the controlled contact register. Daniel reports missing authority, information or service acceptance with the consequence and the decision required. Essential emergency help is not delayed to complete a routine administrative approval chain.

11. Handover and continuing activity. A handover identifies the current plan, open decisions, commitments, information location, relevant service acceptance and the named incoming owner. That person confirms acceptance. The outgoing and incoming roles are recorded separately from the control

room's ongoing responsibilities. If cover is not accepted, Daniel escalates to the duty manager or designated owner; the unresolved obligation is not silently closed or indefinitely assigned to him by default.

12. Review and confirmation. The parties review whether the agreement matches work as performed. They examine unresolved decisions, avoidable rework, late uncommunicated changes, unowned tasks and the usability of cover. They do not use low incident-report numbers as proof that the arrangement is sound. Amendments are versioned, approved by the appropriate owner and communicated to affected people. The executive and EA confirm the agreement; finance, information-access and support-service owners confirm the parts that depend on their authority. No fictional signature is represented as a real approval.

1.7.4 Why the example is specific

The example deliberately avoids statements such as "the assistant handles everything" or "security will take care of it." Each important commitment identifies its boundary. Daniel may spend within a narrow approved category; that does not give him payment authority. Aisha can provide cover; that does not make her permanently on call. Thandi supplies protective input; that does not establish the control room's monitoring acceptance.

It also avoids collecting every possible fact about the executive. The agreement needs a process for handling a private commitment, not its private content. It needs a controlled location for current contacts, not a public list of names and numbers inside the book. This distinction makes a useful template possible without turning the publication into an operational information store.

Specificity should be proportionate. Not every routine task needs a long clause. Start with the areas where ambiguity produces repeated rework, unsafe assumptions or unowned obligations. Where an established policy already answers the question, reference the current controlled policy rather than copying a second version that will become outdated.

1.7.5 Introducing and maintaining the agreement

To introduce the agreement, begin with one or two familiar examples of avoidable friction. Show how clarity would improve the service. Invite the executive to correct your interpretation and ask the affected owners to verify the proposed interfaces. Present the agreement as a practical aid to reliability, not as a defensive document designed to avoid work.

Test the agreement with ordinary scenarios before relying on it under pressure. Can another authorised assistant understand what Daniel may move? Does the spending clause distinguish ordering from payment? Is there a route when Lindiwe is unavailable? Does the deputy know which assignment has actually been accepted? An agreement that cannot answer those questions needs refinement.

Review it when the work changes, not only at an annual meeting. A new executive, altered travel pattern, different provider or additional leader can change the required authority and cover. Keep the prior version available according to the organisation's records arrangements, but make the current version unmistakable.

Reflection 7. Identify three clauses in the Meridian agreement that require confirmation from someone other than Lindiwe and Daniel. Explain why their agreement alone cannot create the necessary authority or service.

1.8 Maintaining a sustainable support arrangement

Illustrative fictional case: an incoming deputy explicitly accepts defined cover; access or a sent message alone is not acceptance.

1.8.1 Continuity is not permanent personal availability

An executive may travel outside normal office hours. A support obligation may continue after an assistant's duty period. Those facts create a need for defined coverage; they do not automatically make one person responsible for remaining available indefinitely. The organisation must decide which service is required, who provides it and how responsibility transfers.

UK HSE's guidance on work demands refers to achievable demands within agreed hours and work matched to people's capabilities. It is a useful general reference for discussing workload, not a statement of the employment terms or legal position that apply to every reader. The course's practical requirement is to make capacity and cover explicit. [S5]

For the EA, sustainability begins with an honest view of the work. Record the planned commitments, likely interruptions, preparation requirements and time needed for quality checking. When new tasks

consume that capacity, make the effect visible. Do not build the service on a hidden assumption that the assistant will always absorb the difference privately.

1.8.2 Personal tasks and professional limits

Personal administrative work can be a legitimate part of some support roles, but it must be agreed rather than inferred from loyalty or familiarity. Establish which tasks are included, who may request them, how costs are handled, what information is necessary and how conflicts with business work are resolved.

An instruction to arrange an appointment is different from authority to obtain private records. Contact with a family member is different from a general permission to disclose the executive's location. A helpful relationship with a household employee does not authorise the assistant to investigate private affairs or manage a family dispute.

Where a personal task falls outside the existing arrangement, clarify the need and the appropriate route. You can assist by identifying a legitimate service or arranging an authorised conversation. You do not have to accept unlimited personal responsibility to demonstrate commitment to the executive.

1.8.3 Build cover before absence

A deputy arrangement needs more than a name. The deputy must know the required work, have the necessary competence and access, understand the current authority limits and accept the period of responsibility. The executive and relevant colleagues should know when the deputy is acting and where to send requests.

Use the deputy's individual authorised access. Do not make continuity depend on copying passwords or forwarding every private message. A small, maintained support record can be more useful than a large archive of unfiltered correspondence. The record should point to the current programme, approvals, contacts and unresolved actions through the approved access structure.

Prepare for both planned and unplanned absence. During planned leave, a joint review may be possible. During an unexpected absence, the designated manager must be able to activate the approved cover arrangement without relying on the absent EA to reconstruct everything. A practice handover can reveal missing permissions and unclear ownership before the gap matters.

1.8.4 The handover that transfers responsibility

A handover is complete when the incoming owner can understand and accept the continuing work. A sent attachment is not enough. Confirm the scope, the time of transfer, any limitations and where unresolved matters go. Record acceptance in a proportionate way that the relevant people can retrieve.

Consider Meridian's afternoon site visit. In a later case update, the approved activity continues beyond Daniel's 17:00 finish. Aisha has agreed a defined administrative cover period and the control room has separately accepted monitoring under its fictional service arrangement. Daniel must give Aisha the current information and outstanding decisions, not simply say "the room is handling it."

The control room's role and the deputy's role may continue in parallel. The room may own monitoring and alert coordination while Aisha owns an administrative change or communication. The handover should not imply that one automatically replaces the other. Nor should a change to the EA cover period silently amend the provider's monitoring scope.

UK HSE's lone-working guidance includes agreed contact arrangements, monitoring and confirmation of return. Those principles are used here by analogy. The detailed executive-support handover model is a proposed course method, not a claim that every executive is a lone worker. [S6; R1, section 7]

BOUNDARY | When cover has not been accepted

Do not record a transfer that has not occurred. Escalate the gap to the appointed manager or duty owner, state what continues and request an explicit arrangement. The solution is neither silent abandonment nor an unspoken requirement that the outgoing EA remain responsible without limit.

1.8.5 Protect the assistant's own safety and judgement

The EA is part of the group the support arrangement should protect. Do not send an assistant to confront a threatening visitor, investigate an unexplained location or resolve an incident physically because they know the executive well. The companion awareness guide's people-first and non-investigative boundary remains applicable. [A1, p. 6]

A concern about workload, unsafe instructions or inadequate information should be raised before it becomes an error. State the observed problem and its consequence rather than diagnosing yourself or someone else. "I cannot complete both checks within the available time; one needs to be reassigned" is actionable. So is "the after-hours owner has not accepted the activity."

Managers should respond by clarifying priorities, authority and support rather than asking the assistant to hide uncertainty. The proposed course model treats a well-founded report of a gap as useful information. It does not promise that every organisation already has that culture; the working agreement should identify how concerns will actually be handled.

1.8.6 Review the relationship, not only the workload

A periodic review should ask whether the service still fits the executive's objectives, whether decisions arrive in time, whether the assistant can work within the agreed authority, and whether another authorised person can provide cover. Discuss changes in workload and the effectiveness of the communication rhythm.

Use a few meaningful examples. An unresolved approval that repeatedly arrives late may require a different decision route. A supplier repeatedly bypassing the agreed contact may need a clear joint message. An assistant who is asked for the same information in several places may need a better controlled record, not another reporting form.

Recognise useful independent judgement as well as speed. An assistant who identifies a gap and obtains the correct decision is not necessarily slower than one who marks every task complete. The latter may simply be transferring unrecognised risk and rework to other people.

Reflection 8. What must be true before you can say that a deputy has taken over an evening activity? Distinguish the deputy's acceptance from any continuing control-room responsibilities.

1.9 Putting the partnership into practice

1.9.1 Revisit the Meridian morning

Daniel now applies the working method to the opening case. He does not start by assuming that every request must be accommodated. He reviews the approved programme, identifies the current priorities and prepares the decisions that Lindiwe actually needs to make.

The verified starting position is deliberately limited. Preparation is scheduled for 09:30 to 10:00. The decision meeting is 10:00 to 10:45. The client discussion is virtual at 11:30. The private commitment begins at 12:30. The afternoon site visit has accepted arrangements within its existing scope. The supplier request and lunch proposal are changes; they are not yet complete commitments.

Daniel records that the supplier's claimed approval is unverified and that the proposed lunch has not yet received the necessary consequential decisions. He does not infer that the existing site-visit arrangements cover it. He also does not seek the personal explanation behind the private time block merely to make the calendar easier to manipulate.

1.9.2 The conversation that resolves the business choice

Daniel gives Lindiwe a short brief. "The supplier's proposed time overlaps your preparation and the decision meeting. Their stated issue is a delivery sequence. I recommend asking operations to handle it and bring you any unresolved decision. The lunch option changes the venue and may conflict with your private block; it also needs revised protective and monitoring arrangements. Keeping the client discussion virtual preserves the current programme."

Lindiwe confirms that the decision meeting and private block remain. She authorises Daniel to ask the operations owner to handle the supplier discussion and chooses to retain the virtual client discussion. Daniel records those decisions. He then obtains the operations owner's acceptance and the client's confirmation of the original virtual arrangement. These later confirmations are explicit fictional case developments, not facts he was entitled to assume at the start.

Before the protected preparation period, the finance owner supplies the approved paper and Daniel checks its version against the pack record. This is a further fictional case development, not a confirmation he could assume earlier.

The afternoon visit remains unchanged. Daniel checks the current record rather than duplicating completed specialist work or announcing a new approval. The lesson is proportion: investigate the status of the relevant dependency, not every possible risk in the executive's life.

1.9.3 The professional record

A concise decision record is sufficient to show how the morning was resolved.

Matter	Decision or status	Owner and evidence
09:45 supplier request	Proposed executive appointment not accepted; discussion referred to operations after Lindiwe's approval.	Daniel records Lindiwe's decision and the operations owner's acceptance.
09:30 preparation	Retained.	Daniel records receipt and version-checking of the approved paper before preparation.
10:00 decision meeting	Retained.	Lindiwe remains the executive decision-maker; document owners retain their substantive responsibilities.
Client lunch proposal	Not taken forward; virtual discussion retained.	Daniel records the business decision and client's confirmation. No revised physical-venue approval is invented.
Private commitment	Protected time block retained.	No unnecessary personal detail is collected or distributed.
Afternoon site visit	Existing accepted scope retained; material changes would follow the agreed route.	Daniel refers to the current controlled arrangement.

The record separates decisions from their implementation. It also preserves the boundaries of Daniel's contribution. He has not made the investment decision, determined the supplier's delivery sequence or performed a protective assessment. He has made it easier for each appointed owner to do the right work.

1.9.4 A later handover

Later in the fictional day, a confirmed activity continues after Daniel's normal finish. Aisha has accepted administrative cover for the stated period and the control room's assigned duty holder has confirmed the monitoring record relevant to that activity. Daniel gives Aisha the current plan, references to the accepted service scope, open actions and the approved route for any unresolved decision.

Aisha confirms what she has accepted. Where a responsibility belongs to the control room, the handover states that explicitly rather than transferring it to her by implication. Daniel records the transition and informs the people who need to know whom to contact. The support arrangement continues because it was organised, not because Daniel remains privately available indefinitely.

1.9.5 What success looks like

There is no dramatic rescue in this case. No one is portrayed as incompetent or malicious. Success consists of a prepared executive, preserved commitments, an accepted delegation, limited disclosure and a support record that another person can use. Those ordinary outcomes are the foundation for more demanding work later in the programme.

The case also shows what remains outside the assistant's control. Another owner may deliver a paper late. A client may decline an alternative. A provider may have a genuine coverage limitation. The EA cannot

guarantee those external actions. The professional response is to make the dependency visible, obtain a decision and avoid describing the unresolved matter as complete.

1.9.6 Five questions for your own practice

Before accepting a substantial support responsibility, ask these five questions.

Is the required result clear?

Do I have authority for the responsibility I am accepting?

Is the necessary information available?

Have competing demands been resolved?

Can the task be completed or properly handed over?

These questions express the unit's five supporting outcomes in everyday language. They are not a demand to produce a form for every conversation. With practice, they become a disciplined way of noticing what matters and bringing the right question to the right person.

KEY POINT | The partnership standard

A capable EA does not make uncertainty disappear by changing the wording. The EA makes uncertainty visible, assigns the appropriate decision and keeps the work moving within a clear mandate.

Practical toolkit

The following tools are original, reusable teaching templates. Complete them with fictional or sanitised information for learning. Before workplace use, reconcile them with the organisation's actual role descriptions, authority, privacy arrangements and service procedures. A completed form is evidence of a conversation or decision only when the relevant people have actually confirmed it.

Tool T1.1 - Executive support brief

Executive role and current business purpose: State the responsibilities and results the support arrangement must enable. Do not copy a job title without explaining the current work.

Priority and intended result: Identify the priority, why it matters now and the business result sought. Distinguish the result from an activity such as "hold a meeting."

EA deliverable and completion evidence: Define what you will produce or coordinate, who will use it and how its readiness will be checked.

Decision and input owners: Name roles for the substantive decision, required papers and other dependencies. Use a separate controlled directory for real personal contact details.

Review point and consequence of a gap: State when readiness will be reviewed, what happens if an input is late and who decides the alternative.

Capacity and support needs: Identify information, access, time, resources or deputy support that must be provided. Mark unconfirmed items as unconfirmed.

Tool T1.2 - Executive-EA working agreement

This blank structure follows the worked agreement in section 1.7. Complete each field with usable arrangements, not slogans. Extend a field when the role genuinely needs more detail; reference an existing controlled policy where it already answers the question.

Agreement area	Record the agreed arrangement
Identity and review	Agreement reference; executive and EA roles; version; effective point; review triggers; approving roles.
Purpose and priorities	Main support results; deliverables; decision points; method for resolving competing priorities.
Included and excluded work	Administrative scope; combined duties; specialist owners; explicitly excluded decisions or tasks.
Diary and information access	Required delegated access; protected blocks; minimum operational detail; restricted-information route.
Decision and spending authority	Independent actions; conditions and limits; approval owner; exceptions; distinction between ordering, approval and payment.
Communication	Routine review rhythm; approved channels; urgent route; capture of verbal decisions; fallback channel.
Confidentiality and personal tasks	Permitted work; verified recipients; information limits; family-liaison boundary; route for a new request.
Protective and monitoring interfaces	Required EPO decisions; actual service coverage; assignment acceptance; uncovered-activity escalation.
Availability and deputy	Duty periods; agreed additional coverage; deputy competence and access; explicit acceptance of each cover arrangement.
Concerns and handover	Routine decision route; alternative concern-reporting route; handover content; incoming acceptance; owner of a coverage gap.
Confirmation and changes	Confirming parties; outstanding dependencies; current-policy references; method for communicating a revised version.

Confirmation check: What part of the agreement depends on a person or service not yet consulted? Until that dependency is confirmed, do not describe the whole arrangement as operationally complete.

Tool T1.3 - Delegation and priority decision brief

The request: Describe the result sought, its source and the latest useful decision time. Identify any claimed approval that remains unverified.

Current commitments and constraints: State what would be displaced, which preparation or other dependency is affected and any policy, authority or service condition that applies.

Options: Set out feasible alternatives. For each one, explain what is preserved, what changes, the relevant cost or workload implication and what remains conditional.

Recommendation: Give a reason tied to the agreed business objective. Do not conceal an inconvenient consequence to make your preferred option look stronger.

Decision required: State who must decide and what the decision needs to cover. Separate the executive's business preference from a specialist decision or provider acceptance.

Implementation and closure: Record the actual decision, the people who must act, the acknowledgements needed and the evidence of completion or accepted transfer.

Tool T1.4 - Cover and handover record

Field	Information needed for a usable transfer
Assignment and period	Identify the work being transferred and the start and end of the cover period.
Current plan	Reference the current programme or record and explain material changes.
Authority and access	State what the incoming person may do and confirm usable individual access.
Open work	Record unresolved decisions, deadlines, dependencies and their owners.
Protective or service interfaces	Identify the accepted service scope and responsibilities that stay with the EPO, control room or other owner.
Exceptions and fallback	State the approved decision route and who owns a missing-coverage problem.
Acceptance and notification	Record the incoming person's acceptance and notify the people who need the new contact route.
Closure	Record completion or the next accepted transfer; do not close continuing work merely because the outgoing duty period ended.

Tool T1.5 - Partnership review conversation

Discuss one example of support that worked well and one example of avoidable friction. Ask whether the priorities were clear, whether the assistant had usable authority and information, whether changes were communicated and whether the work remained coverable. Identify a specific adjustment, its owner and the evidence that will show whether it helped.

Do not turn the review into a count of how often the assistant said yes or how rarely anyone reported a concern. The useful question is whether the arrangement enabled reliable work without concealing gaps or overloading a person. Retain only the information necessary for the review and follow the organisation's record-handling arrangements.

Working agreement response page

Use Tool T1.2 and the 12-clause worked example. Give a separate response to every area. These learning fields do not create an employment agreement, permission or service obligation.

Identity purpose and work scope

Record the learning agreement reference, version, roles, priorities and included or excluded work.

Access decisions and spending

State permitted access and independent actions, conditions, limits and the separate approval or payment owner.

Communication confidentiality and personal tasks

Define the channels, information limits, escalation and the route for a new personal task.

Cover handover and specialist interfaces

Record the assignment and period, usable access, explicit acceptance and responsibilities retained by other owners.

Confirmation and review

Identify each confirming role, unresolved dependency, effective point and review trigger. Mark absent evidence as unconfirmed.

Practice, reflection and explanatory guidance

The unit practice task

Using the Meridian brief or another clearly fictional brief, produce a working agreement and a short priority-and-delegation exercise. Include the support objectives, authority boundaries, information access, communication preferences, personal-task limits, availability, escalation and deputy arrangements. Then explain your response to one competing-demand problem.

Your submission should make the distinction between proposed arrangements and confirmed facts explicit. A blank approval field is not a failure when the fictional brief has not supplied approval. Inventing an approval to make the form look finished is a failure of judgement. Identify who must confirm the outstanding matter and what cannot proceed as complete until they do.

Write your decision brief

Use the starting Meridian case before the later confirmations in section 1.9.2. Do not invent an approval. Refer to the worked agreement in section 1.7.3 and Tool T1.3.

Result and existing constraint

What is requested, and which commitment or preparation would it affect?

_____

_____

Options and recommendation

State workable options, their consequences and the reason for your recommendation.

_____

_____

Separate decisions and acceptance

Identify the business decision, any specialist input and each owner who must accept work.

_____

_____

Unknowns and next review

What is not yet confirmed? Who must resolve it, by when, and what stays conditional?

_____

_____

Use the following review guide. It is a learning aid, not the final course examination or a claim of workplace authorisation.

Supporting outcome	Evidence to look for
EA-01.1	Priorities are translated into defined EA deliverables, named input or decision owners and useful review points.
EA-01.2	The agreement addresses every specified area and identifies the authority or service dependencies that require confirmation.
EA-01.3	The learner distinguishes neighbouring and specialist roles without assuming universal title-based powers.
EA-01.4	Options are feasible, consequences are explained and conditional matters are not presented as already approved.
EA-01.5	There is a usable concern-reporting route and an accepted cover process, not an assumption of permanent personal availability.

Guidance for Reflection 1 - Separate action from assumption

Daniel can review the current programme, identify conflicts, verify the supplier's request and prepare a decision brief. He can ask the relevant people for information through approved channels. He cannot yet claim that the supplier appointment, lunch transport or revised monitoring is confirmed. The executive must decide the business preference and any changed commitment; the relevant specialist and service owners must separately confirm matters within their responsibilities.

A strong answer does not treat the whole request as impossible. It identifies useful work that can proceed while preserving the status of the matters that remain unresolved.

Guidance for Reflection 2 - Access does not create approval authority

The assistant can identify the supplier process, confirm which owner may approve the exception and prepare the information that owner needs. Unless the actual delegation permits the approval, the assistant should not issue it simply because of proximity to the chief executive. A defensible response is helpful and specific: "I will route the request with its reason and deadline to the appointed approver; I am not authorised to approve that exception myself."

Guidance for Reflection 3 - Convert readiness into evidence

A useful support requirement identifies the decision being prepared, the agenda and approved papers needed, their owners, the preparation period and a readiness review. If an essential paper remains unapproved, the assistant flags it to the appropriate owner and executive, explains the effect on preparation and seeks the required decision. The assistant must not label a draft as approved or make the substantive decision personally.

Guidance for Reflection 4 - Correct the record and the action

An adequate message makes the corrected appointment time prominent, states that the earlier time is superseded and identifies any affected action such as transport or attendance. It reaches the people who must act and obtains the relevant acknowledgement. It does not include unnecessary personal information or hide the correction inside a long unrelated message. The controlled programme must also be corrected, not only the email.

Guidance for Reflection 5 - Define the routine boundary

A good delegation might permit changes to a routine internal catch-up within agreed available periods, provided no protected commitment, cost or specialist dependency is affected. It should refer a changed external venue, an affected executive decision meeting or a change involving additional expenditure to the appropriate owner. The record should include the result, scope, conditions, decision route, evidence and review point. The exact limits must come from the real or fictional brief, not from the learner's assumption.

Guidance for Reflection 6 - Keep approvals distinct

The lunch brief should show the proposed business benefit, the effect on the current programme and private block, and the alternative of retaining the virtual discussion. The physical option remains subject to the required protective input, transport arrangements and monitoring acceptance. No blanket waiting period or service guarantee should be invented. A recommendation is acceptable when its reason and conditions are explicit.

Guidance for Reflection 7 - Identify the other owners

Examples include finance confirming spending and payment controls, the information-access owner confirming delegated permissions, and the EPO or control-room owner confirming their actual role and service arrangements. HR or the designated manager may also need to confirm availability and cover arrangements. Lindiwe and Daniel can agree how they wish to work together, but they cannot create another function's authority or a provider's service obligation by writing it into their own document.

Guidance for Reflection 8 - Demonstrate accepted cover

The incoming deputy needs a defined assignment and period, usable access, current information, open actions and the relevant authority and escalation route. Acceptance must be explicit. The control room's monitoring role continues under its separately accepted mandate; it is not automatically transferred to the deputy. An unaccepted gap goes to the designated manager or duty owner for resolution rather than disappearing at the end of a shift.

Common weaknesses to correct

A weak agreement describes personal qualities but not decisions. A weak priority exercise says which request wins without explaining the consequence. A weak handover names a deputy but provides neither acceptance nor access. A weak role comparison assumes that a title grants authority. Correct these weaknesses by returning to the work itself: result, owner, conditions, evidence and the next decision.

A serious boundary error should be corrected and the relevant task demonstrated again. The aim is not to punish a learner for recognising uncertainty. It is to prevent unsafe or unsupported decisions from being hidden by a polished form or by strong performance on an unrelated question. [R2, assessment-design recommendations]

Unit summary and key terms

The foundation you have built

Executive support begins with the purpose of the work. The assistant translates that purpose into deliverables, protects preparation and makes dependencies visible. Reliability depends on explicit priorities, authority, information access, communication and cover.

The working agreement records a shared understanding, not merely a signature. It must help people respond to conflicting requests and absence. The EA coordinates with the EPO and control room without taking over their responsibilities. Carry that distinction into every later unit; LU2 develops the boundaries in detail.

Key terms used in this unit

Term	Meaning in this book
Authority	Permission to make a specified decision or perform an action within defined conditions.
Commitment	Work or an arrangement that has been accepted by the appropriate party, not merely requested.
Controlled record	The identified current record maintained through an agreed process, with material changes traceable.
Delegation	Assignment of defined work or decision rights with scope, limits and a completion expectation.
Dependency	An input, decision, resource or action on which another task depends.
Executive Protection Officer (EPO)	The appointed protection professional whose decisions and activities remain within the actual mandate.
Handover	An explicit transfer of defined continuing work to an incoming owner who accepts it.
Independent remote control room	The monitoring and coordination facility described in the programme; its powers and coverage depend on its real service mandate.
Mandate	The agreed scope and authority of a role, read with the applicable organisational requirements.
Priority	Work whose relative importance and timing have been considered against the agreed objectives and constraints.
Protective coordination	The EA's authorised organisation of information, decisions and interfaces that support the protective arrangement.
Working agreement	A practical record of how the executive-support partnership operates within existing authority and policy.

References and further reading

The project documents below establish the course's scope and outcomes. The external references support specific background points, not the invented Meridian case or its numerical examples. Website pages were checked on 6 October 2026. The UK guidance is used for transferable principles only. No accreditation, legal equivalence or endorsement is claimed.

R1. Course-development project. Executive Assistant: Research Foundation and Development Brief, version 1.0, 6 October 2026. Especially sections 1, 5-8, 10 and 11. The project basis for professional support, role interfaces, daily coordination, safe boundaries and the independent-book approach.

R2. Course-development project. Executive Assistant: Course Learning Outcomes, version 1.0, 6 October 2026. EA-01 and EA-01.1 to EA-01.5; associated evidence and quality standard. The source for the unit's learning requirements, not a workplace authorisation.

A1. User-supplied companion guide. Tiger Kidnapping in Telecommunications: Executive and Family Awareness Guide, first edition, 2026. Pages 6 and 11. Used for the people-first, non-investigative boundary and the relevance of executive-support information. The cases, wording and artwork are not reproduced here.

S1. National Center for O*NET Development. Executive Secretaries and Executive Administrative Assistants, occupation 43-6011.00, updated 2026. Occupational background on the breadth of executive administration; not a local job specification. Official source: www.onetonline.org

S2. World Administrators Alliance. Global Skills Matrix: Foundation Report, 2021, page 4. Background on variation and overlap in administrative titles. No level or credential is assigned to this course. Official source: wa-alliance.com

S3. The EA Campus. Effective Calendar Management Online Course, public course outline. Supports the general emphasis on priority alignment and preparation. Proprietary course worksheets and instruction are not reproduced. Official source: theeacampus.com

S4. UK Health and Safety Executive. Management Standards - Role. General reference for clear responsibilities, compatible requirements and routes to raise role concerns. Official source: www.hse.gov.uk

S5. UK Health and Safety Executive. Management Standards - Demands. General reference for achievable demands, agreed hours and capability. Official source: www.hse.gov.uk

S6. UK Health and Safety Executive. Lone working: Training, supervision and monitoring. Contact, monitoring and return-confirmation principles used by analogy, not an EA-specific procedure. Official source: www.hse.gov.uk

Word help

These explanations support the learning unit. The original workbook's key terms remain in the unit summary above.

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